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## Tamil Nadu emerging as India's sporting hub

**T**amil Nadu is quietly scripting one of India's most compelling sporting stories. At the PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit, senior officials outlined how the State has married grassroots programmes, elite athlete support, and marquee international events to build a national sporting powerhouse.

This success is closely tied to the State's Olympic Quest scheme initiated by the government. The programme rests on three pillars: hiring top foreign coaches at competitive salaries, setting up Olympic academies, and providing high incentives/jobs to medal prospects. Tamil Nadu has also borrowed ideas from elsewhere. "A delegation led by our Deputy Chief Minister visited Odisha," recalled Dr. Atulya Misra (centre), IAS, Additional Chief Secretary to the Government,

Department of Youth Welfare and Sports Development. "There, the government builds infrastructure while corporates provide the soft power — coaching, management, international expertise. Tamil Nadu has adapted this approach, but with larger budgetary support."

"A fact-finding delegation to Paris found that in at least 10-15 Olympic disciplines, India has no representation — like BMX, climbing, taekwondo, and there is feeble representation in rugby sevens, softball, handball," Atulya added. The proposed Sports City will therefore include facilities like BMX tracks and

climbing walls, ensuring Indian athletes at least have exposure.

Yet the officials admitted that gaps remain. "High-performance centres are valuable for elite athletes, but corporates should also invest at the grassroots level. Many young athletes lack basic financial support for equipment or travel," said J. Meghanatha Reddy (left), IAS, Member Secretary and CEO, Tamil Nadu Sports Development Authority.

The Tamil Nadu Champions Foundation has stepped into this gap. Reddy cited the story of M. Khazima, daughter of an auto driver, who needed ₹1.5 lakh to compete at the Carrom World Cup in the U.S. last year. "We supported her, and she went on to win the singles crown."

Tamil Nadu's sporting footprint extends well beyond the Olympic arena. The State has produced 34 of India's 89 chess Grandmasters, two World chess champions, four Paris Paralympic medallists, and 12 Olympians. At the Hangzhou Asian and Para Asian Games, TN athletes contributed to 43 medals.

Tamil Nadu has already staged the Chess Olympiad, Squash World Cup, and Asian Surfing Championship.

